

LOCALISATION AN INTRODUCTION

This article is aimed at language computing enthusiasts interested in using computing devices in their native language, developers interested in supporting localisation, linguists interested in understanding translation issues, and business managers exploring the potential of localisation.

If you have ever tried to install an operating system, you will be greeted with several questions concerning the configuration of the system. It could be the location, which determines properties like the time zone, date format and the type of keyboard, and the support for additional languages. These settings also aid in the setting-up of software servers for updates. The technology behind this is called *Localisation*. It is also referred to as *I18n*, as there are ten letters between 'l' and 'n'. For example, Ubuntu 11.04 was released with support for 60 languages.

The configuration of a computing device to enable usage in a language chosen by users, and in an environment familiar to them, is called *Localisation*. When computers were originally developed in the West, they only had support for English-speaking countries. As the use of computers increased worldwide, the need to operate the computer in a language of the user's choice grew in importance. Suppliers had to adapt to this need by developing different versions of software and hardware. Even when hardware cannot be customised, software can be modified to support localisation needs.

The importance of localisation

While English has become the *lingua franca* of the international business world, there are over 6909 languages used in the world, as per Lewis, M Paul (ed.), 2009. *Ethnologue: Languages of the World*, Sixteenth edition. Dallas, Tex. (<http://www.ethnologue.com/>). Huge populations are deprived of the full benefit of computing if the devices do not support their preferred languages. Without technology's help, there is a danger that these languages could become extinct. When a language dies, the rich cultural heritage of a segment of the world population disappears. Hence, localisation is important.

More and more operating systems and application software are being localised. This is opening up employment opportunities too, for people skilled in languages and computers.



Figure 1: Ubuntu 11.04 in Telugu (<http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Ubuntu11.04Te2DUnity>)